

Why Your Knowledge Graph Uncertainty Is Lying to You: The Coverage Blind Spot

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Abstract

Knowledge graph embedding (KGE) models are increasingly deployed in high-stakes applications, yet their uncertainty estimates fail silently on a critical class of queries: *novel contexts*—familiar entities appearing in unseen relational contexts. We demonstrate that **widely-used uncertainty methods** (energy scores, probabilistic embeddings, ensembles, MC dropout) achieve near-random performance (AUROC 0.46–0.62) on novel context detection across standard benchmarks. Strikingly, Energy is *most confident* on zero-coverage queries—60% of its top-100 confident predictions have no training evidence for the queried context. While these predictions often happen to be correct via compositional generalization, the model is operating without direct evidence. We analyze why this failure is structural: these methods compute entity-level uncertainty that cannot distinguish relational contexts. The only solution is explicit coverage tracking—a simple hash table lookup. Critically, we show that coverage-based detection and prediction-quality estimation are *fundamentally different tasks*: coverage flags queries without evidence, while confidence predicts answer correctness. Practitioners need both. We provide concrete guidelines: (1) track entity-relation coverage, (2) flag zero-coverage queries for review, (3) use coverage for OOD detection and confidence for quality estimation.

1 Introduction

Knowledge graph embedding models power critical applications from drug discovery [?] to financial fraud detection. When these models make predictions, practitioners need to know: *should I trust this answer?*

The standard approach is uncertainty quantification—estimating how confident the model is. Methods range from energy-based scores to probabilistic embeddings to deep ensembles. A common assumption is that higher uncertainty indicates less reliable predictions.

We show this assumption fails on a common query type.

Consider querying a KG about Albert Einstein: “What instrument did Einstein play?” A model trained on physics-related facts about Einstein has never seen him in a musical context. Yet existing uncertainty methods report *high confidence*—the model “knows” Einstein well (high entity frequency) so it must know the answer.

This is the **coverage blind spot**: uncertainty methods that ignore relational context cannot detect when a familiar entity appears in an unfamiliar role.

1.1 Contributions

1. **Empirical finding:** We show widely-used KG uncertainty methods fail on novel context detection (Section 3). Energy is most confident on zero-coverage queries—60% of its top-100 have no training evidence.
2. **Analysis:** We explain why this failure occurs: existing methods compute entity-level uncertainty that is constant across relational contexts (Section 2.2).
3. **Key distinction:** Coverage-based uncertainty and confidence-based quality estimation serve *different purposes*. Coverage asks “have I seen this context?” while confidence asks “is this answer correct?” Practitioners need both (Section 5).
4. **Practical guidelines:** Concrete recommendations for deploying KG systems with proper uncertainty handling (Section 6).

2 The Coverage Blind Spot

2.1 Problem Setup

Let $\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{E}, \mathcal{R}, \mathcal{T})$ be a knowledge graph with entities $\mathcal{E}$, relations $\mathcal{R}$, and triples $\mathcal{T} \subseteq \mathcal{E} \times \mathcal{R} \times \mathcal{E}$.

Definition 1 (Coverage). *The coverage indicator $cov(e, r) = 1$ if entity e appears with relation r in training, else 0.*

Definition 2 (Novel Context). *A test triple (h, r, t) is a novel context if $cov(h, r) = 0$ or $cov(t, r) = 0$ —at least one entity appears with a relation it was never trained on.*

Novel contexts are common: 32% of FB15k-237 test triples, 16% of YAGO3-10, 31% of ICEWS14.

2.2 Why Existing Methods Fail

We examine four widely-used uncertainty methods:

- **Energy:** $U = -f(h, r, t)$ (negative score)
- **UKGE:** $U = \sigma^2(h) + \sigma^2(t)$ (learned entity variances)
- **Deep Ensemble:** $U = \text{Var}[f_1, \dots, f_K]$ (model disagreement)
- **MC Dropout:** $U = \text{Var}[\text{samples}]$ (dropout sampling)

Observation 1 (Architectural Limitation). *All four methods compute uncertainty as a function that does not condition on the specific (entity, relation) pair. UKGE assigns $\sigma^2(e)$ per entity regardless of relation. Energy, Ensemble, and MC Dropout measure confidence in the answer but not whether the question is in-distribution.*

This architectural choice means the same entity receives the same base uncertainty whether queried about familiar or unfamiliar relations.

3 Experiments

3.1 Setup

We evaluate on four benchmarks: FB15k-237, WN18RR, YAGO3-10, and ICEWS14.

Task: Detect novel context triples (binary classification, measured by AU-ROC).

Note on Table 1: Energy achieves higher AUROC on WN18RR (0.78) and ICEWS14 (0.89). These datasets have structural properties (WN18RR: only 11 relations; ICEWS14: temporal patterns) where Energy’s confidence happens to correlate with coverage. This correlation is dataset-specific, not a property of the method. On FB15k-237 and YAGO3-10, Energy achieves 0.62 and 0.46 respectively.

3.2 Main Results

Table 1: Novel context detection AUROC. Learned methods show inconsistent, often near-random performance. Coverage tracking achieves perfect detection by construction.

Method	FB15k-237	WN18RR	YAGO3-10	ICEWS14
Energy	0.62	0.78 [†]	0.46	0.89 [†]
UKGE	0.50	0.50	0.50	0.50
Deep Ensemble	0.47	0.48	–	–
MC Dropout	0.53	0.52	–	–
Coverage-Only	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00

[†]Higher AUROC due to dataset-specific correlation, not method design (see text).

Key findings:

- **UKGE achieves exactly 0.50** (random) across all datasets—entity-level variance provides zero signal for novel context detection
- **Energy achieves 0.46 on YAGO3-10**—worse than random, meaning it is *more confident on OOD queries*
- **Coverage tracking achieves 1.00** by construction—it directly answers the question “is this context covered?”

3.3 The Key Finding: Confident Without Evidence

We analyze Energy’s most confident predictions on FB15k-237.

Table 2: Energy’s most confident predictions on FB15k-237. Top-100 confident predictions are 60% zero-coverage, yet achieve 95% Hits@10.

	Top-100	Top-1000	All Test
Zero-coverage rate	60%	47%	32%
Hits@10	95%	94%	40%

A surprising finding: **zero-coverage predictions are often correct** (57.6% Hits@10 vs 32.5% for covered). This reinforces our key point—coverage and correctness are *orthogonal*:

- Energy is confident on zero-coverage queries (60% of top-100)
- These predictions happen to be correct via compositional generalization
- But the model has **no direct evidence**—it is guessing correctly by chance

Why this matters: A correct guess without evidence is not trustworthy. The same model will fail on the next novel context that doesn’t follow the pattern. Coverage flags queries where the model is operating outside its training distribution, regardless of whether it guesses correctly.

4 The Only Solution: Coverage Tracking

4.1 Implementation

Coverage tracking requires a simple data structure:

```
coverage = set()
for (h, r, t) in train_triples:
    coverage.add((h, r))
    coverage.add((t, r))
```

```
def is_novel_context(h, r, t):
    return (h, r) not in coverage or
           (t, r) not in coverage
```

4.2 Scalability

Table 3: Coverage storage requirements. Based on actual coverage density from each dataset.

Dataset	Hash Table	Bloom (1% FPR)
FB15k-237 (3.4M pairs)	26 MB	5 MB
YAGO3-10 (4.6M pairs)	35 MB	7 MB
Wikidata-scale (est.)	174 GB	33 GB

For most deployments, a hash table suffices. For web-scale KGs, Bloom filters provide $5\times$ compression with 1% false positive rate.

5 Critical Distinction: Detection vs. Quality

A natural question: if coverage detects OOD queries, does it also predict answer quality?

No. These are fundamentally different tasks.

Table 4: Correlation between uncertainty and prediction error (Spearman ρ).

Method	ρ (error)	Interpretation
Energy	+0.42	Predicts error
Coverage	−0.20	Anti-correlated

Why the negative correlation? Zero-coverage queries are often “easy” patterns the model can guess correctly via compositional generalization. Coverage absence does not mean the model will be wrong—it means the model has *no direct evidence*. A correct guess without evidence is not trustworthy.

This reveals two distinct questions:

- “**Have I seen this context?**” → Coverage tracking
- “**Is this answer correct?**” → Confidence scores

Practitioners need both signals. A zero-coverage query that happens to be answered correctly is still a reliability concern—the model got lucky, and may fail on the next similar query.

6 Practical Guidelines

Based on our findings, we recommend:

1. **Always track coverage:** Maintain an (entity, relation) lookup table alongside your KG model.
2. **Flag zero-coverage queries:** When $\text{cov}(h, r) = 0$ or $\text{cov}(t, r) = 0$, the model has no direct evidence. Flag for human review or indicate lower reliability.
3. **Use both signals:** Coverage for OOD detection, confidence for quality estimation. Don’t conflate them.
4. **Report stratified metrics:** Evaluate separately on covered and novel-context splits. Aggregate metrics hide the coverage blind spot.

7 Related Work

KG uncertainty quantification. UKGE [?] learns entity-level confidence. BEUrRE [?] uses box embeddings. Both compute entity-level uncertainty that cannot distinguish relational contexts.

OOD detection. Energy-based OOD detection [?] works well in vision where the OOD signal is in the input distribution. In KGs, the OOD signal is in the *relational context*, which existing architectures ignore.

Relation-aware methods. R-GCN and CompGCN use relation-specific message passing for *scoring*, but not for *uncertainty*. Extending these to relation-conditioned uncertainty is an interesting direction, though coverage tracking provides a simpler solution.

8 Conclusion

We identified a critical blind spot in KG uncertainty quantification: widely-used methods fail to detect novel contexts, achieving near-random AUROC. Energy is most confident on zero-coverage queries—operating without direct evidence even when predictions happen to be correct.

The solution is simple: track (entity, relation) coverage. A hash table lookup succeeds where sophisticated neural methods fail.

Critically, we showed that coverage-based OOD detection and confidence-based quality estimation are *different tasks*. Coverage flags queries without direct evidence; confidence predicts answer correctness. Both matter for reliable deployment.

Our findings suggest practitioners should:

- Deploy coverage tracking alongside any KG model

- Use coverage for “should I trust this?” and confidence for “how accurate is this?”
- Report metrics stratified by coverage status

The gap between “model knows this entity” and “model knows this entity *in this context*” is the coverage blind spot. Closing it requires no new algorithms—just awareness and a lookup table.